

Building Identity through Cuisine

Franklin contrasts the cuisine of Afro-Virginians with that of Anglo-Virginians—that is, she compares the diet of enslaved people with that of slaveholders. The largest difference is in the frequency of wild foods in the diet. Wild animals—even fish and deer—were uncommon in the diet of Anglo-Virginians; cattle were roughly 70% of the total bone count, and beef likely composed even more of the diet, since cattle bones hold much more meat than those of the much smaller pigs, sheep, and goats. Compare this with the diet of Afro-Virginians; cattle bones made up, at most, 50% of all bones in their trash—roughly equal to pig bones. Cattle bones outnumbered pig bones three to one in Anglo-Virginian trash deposits. Franklin also notes another aspect of the diet of enslaved individuals: In most of the 18th century, they likely received entire animals as rations, but by the end of the 18th century, they were receiving precut meat portions, and the extremities (feet and heads) were missing from their trash. As different meat cuts became differently valued, white owners kept the most valued portions for themselves, using cheaper cuts of meat as slave rations.

Franklin makes the argument that the emphasis on beef and, to a lesser extent, pork in the Anglo-Virginian diet was a reaction to the importance of fish and other wild caught foods in the diet of enslaved people: "In Tidewater Virginia, the low price of fish and the decline in its consumption by white households toward the end of the eighteenth century may be related to its centrality in the diet of enslaved blacks. Whites had undoubtedly established the connection between fish and 'blackness' given the role of enslaved blacks as major players in the selling of fish and oysters in Virginia markets" (p. 102). Poultry also acquired a "Black" identity due to the relative ease with which these animals could be raised during the busy work schedules of enslaved people.

The surprising aspect of this work is how much of the Afro-Virginian diet came to become the diet of enslaved Blacks across the Deep South (South Carolina, Georgia, Mississippi, and Alabama), after which aspects of that cuisine moved into "Southern" cuisine adopted and spread by whites. Franklin's example of Mary Randolph's 1824 cookbook shows the ways in which white women could take Black recipes and, by leaving out any mention of their origin, convert them into acceptable white food. And yet, in contemporary African American communities, many of these same dishes are "often strategically essentialized by blacks as a means of establishing common ground and to acknowledge and broadcast a collective identity" (Franklin, p. 105).

But as a footnote to Franklin's study, consider the even deeper history of the foods that became central to Afro-Virginian cuisine and, later, southern Black identity. Note that this "Southern" food, or "soul" food, that is often associated with African Americans today (both by white and Black Americans) is based on a wide variety of crops but especially those selectively adopted by the Creek and other Native cultures, in our example from Gremillion discussed earlier in this module. Consider some of the traditional dishes of "Southern" cuisine: peach pie, black-eyed peas, cornbread, and watermelon. All of these were foods that were widely adopted by Native American communities even before they had direct contact with Euro-Americans. As these Native American communities were driven from their traditional lands by white settlers, those settlers found thriving agricultural systems based on these hybrid foodways that used African, American, and Eurasian domesticates. As enslaved African populations grew in the 18th century, they found themselves exposed to these well-established plant foodways, which provided the opportunity to build upon and further integrate these foods, as well as others, into their cuisine and identity.



Clockwise from top left: a "rustic" peach pie; a bowl of Hoppin' John (a dish of black-eyed peas, collard greens, and rice); southern-style cornbread; and watermelon.

Source: Dr. Marston, [Wikimedia Commons](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Plate_of_Hoppin%27_John.jpg)

(https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Plate_of_Hoppin%27_John.jpg), [Wikimedia Commons](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Skillet_cornbread_(cropped).jpg)

([https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Skillet_cornbread_\(cropped\).jpg](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Skillet_cornbread_(cropped).jpg)), [Wikimedia Commons](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Skillet_cornbread_(cropped).jpg)

([https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Skillet_cornbread_\(cropped\).jpg](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Skillet_cornbread_(cropped).jpg))